

A GUIDED JOURNAL

What They Said

*200 things families said that we're still
healing from – and what we needed to hear
instead*

I didn't write this book.

Thousands of strangers did. One question was asked online — “*What's something a family member said that you'll never fully forgive?*” — and people answered with things they had never said out loud.

I read every answer. I kept the words that stayed with me. And under each one, I wrote what that person deserved to hear instead.

You don't have to read this in order. Open it anywhere. Write, or don't. Put it down when it gets heavy — that's allowed too.

A gentle note: some pages touch on grief, abuse, pregnancy loss, rejection and suicide. Stories have been shortened and changed so no one can be identified. If this brings up something big, please reach out to someone you trust or a support line — there's a list at the back of this book.

How to use this book

Read the story. Each page holds one real thing a family member said.

Read what they needed to hear. The words that person deserved — and maybe you did too.

Then it's your turn. Answer the prompt on the lines below. Write as much or as little as you want. Cross things out. Come back later.

There are no wrong answers here, and no one is grading your healing.

Contents

01	The Favorite & the Forgotten	7
02	Before I Was Even Born	22
03	The Mirror They Handed Me	36
04	Where Grief Should Have Been Held	52
05	The Ones Who Got Blamed	73
06	The Ones Who Didn't Believe Me	87
07	Blood, Paper & Belonging	100
08	Cradles & Cruel Words	113
09	Never Enough	133
10	Loved, or Just Useful?	153
11	The Seat at Their Table	164
12	Who I Am Was the Problem	183
13	The Words That Cut Deepest	196
14	...And Then I Did	224
—	Letters I'll Never Send	235
—	Where to Find Support	242

01

The Favorite & the Forgotten

*For everyone who grew up watching someone else
get the softness they were never given.*

MEASURED AGAINST THEM

LOVED A LITTLE LESS

LEFT OFF THE LIST

When I was 10, my aunt told me her kids would always be better than me. Who says that to a child? Long story short, her kids never accomplished anything and are always in trouble with the law.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never in a race with her children. A grown woman ranking a 10-year-old said everything about her and nothing about you.

YOUR TURN

Who were you measured against growing up? Write down three things you've done that no comparison could ever take from you.

My dad had been drinking. He bragged about my older sister being valedictorian, then turned to me and said I should study harder because I wasn't as smart as her. I was already an honors student. I cried in the bathroom. My stepmom stood up for me.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your effort was never invisible just because he refused to look at it. You were already doing well, and you didn't need to become your sister to count.

YOUR TURN

What did you achieve that got overlooked next to a sibling? Write the praise you deserved, then name the person who stood up for you.

My mother told me that my brother's child will always be her favorite.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Love was never supposed to be ranked out loud. Being told you come second doesn't make you, or your children, any less worth cherishing.

YOUR TURN

Has someone made it clear you or your family came second? Write a promise about how you'll make the people you love feel chosen.

My stepmom said she treated me badly because of my stepsister. She said she didn't want my stepsister to get jealous. I was only a kid, and I was treated terribly.

— shared by a stepdaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never the problem that needed managing. A child deserves kindness in her own home, not to be made smaller so someone else feels bigger.

YOUR TURN

Where were you made smaller to keep someone else comfortable? Write to the kid you were and tell her what she should have been given.

At dinner, my parents called me their "experiment child." They said they knew they treated me differently than my younger brother because they needed to see the difference in reactions.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never a test run. You were a whole child from the start, and you deserved the same care as the one who came after you.

YOUR TURN

Did you ever feel like the practice round in your family? Write down what the first-born you actually needed and never got.

My dad told me I didn't deserve the life I have and that my sister should have my life instead. We are one year no contact now, and I'll never go back.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your life was never a prize you had to earn from him. It is yours, and protecting it was an act of strength, not cruelty.

YOUR TURN

Has someone told you that you didn't deserve what you have? Write a boundary you've set, or want to set, to protect your life.

My mother told me, more than once, that when she left us she only cared about and worried for my younger brother. She wasn't bothered about me at all.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were worth worrying about, even when she didn't. Her lack of concern was a failure in her, not proof that you mattered less.

YOUR TURN

When did you feel like nobody was worried about you? Write a note to your younger self telling her you're checking in on her now.

My mom looked right at me and said, "If anybody were to ever get drafted, I would prefer that you did over your brother."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your safety was never the lesser one. Anyone who could say that out loud revealed their own favoritism, not your worth.

YOUR TURN

Was there a moment you realized you were ranked below a sibling? Write about the people who would choose to protect you.

A family heirloom was always meant for me. When I finally got the family on my side, my mom gave in with, "Yeah, you're family too, I guess." Years later, it still echoes on quiet nights.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

There was no "I guess" about it. You belonged to that family fully, and asking for what was meant for you was never greedy.

YOUR TURN

When were you made to feel like an afterthought in your own family? Write the sentence you deserved instead, with no "I guess" in it.

My mother decided to stop buying me Easter eggs because I was 34 and she "preferred to spend her money on Easter eggs for my child."

— shared by a daughter, 30s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Wanting to be thought of by your mom doesn't expire at any age. A small gesture can carry a big message, and losing it is allowed to hurt.

YOUR TURN

What small tradition or gesture did you lose that meant more than it looked?
Plan one way to give that to yourself this year.

On Thanksgiving, my older brother told me he was “forced” to like me when I was a kid.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never a chore someone got stuck with. You are someone people choose, and his reluctance never measured how likable you are.

YOUR TURN

Who made you feel like you were tolerated instead of wanted? Write down the names of people who choose you on purpose.

My father's last words of wisdom to me were that he didn't want me to be a financial burden on my mother, and he didn't want me to come home anymore. My brother was treated like the prodigal son.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never a burden to be sent away. You deserved a place to come home to, and it's not your fault he couldn't offer one.

YOUR TURN

What did you need to hear from a parent that you never got to hear? Write those last words the way they should have been.

When my dad was at his lowest and planning to end his life, he texted my brothers and my mom a "love you, bye." He never sent one to me. He's still here and we're bonding now, but it still hurts.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Being left off that message didn't mean you were loved less. You're allowed to be glad he's here and still grieve what you didn't get.

YOUR TURN

Where have you felt left off the list in your family? Write the message you deserved to receive, in your own words.

*Being loved less was never
proof that you were worth
less.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

02

Before I Was Even Born

*For the ones who were told, in one way or another,
that they weren't wanted.*

I WISH I'D NEVER HAD YOU
YOU WERE A MISTAKE
HAVING YOU RUINED ME

On my first day of high school, my mom told me she hated me, that she wished I'd never been born, and that she loved my sister more. She hugged my sister, said "I love you," and told me to get out of the car.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never the reason she was unhappy. That morning you deserved a hug and a "good luck," and wanting one was always right.

YOUR TURN

What was a milestone day that someone ruined for you? Rewrite that morning here the way it should have gone.

My mother recently said that I am the daughter she never wanted, and that she is the mother I never wanted. I am 55, and that hurt.

— shared by a daughter, 50s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

It's never too late for words like that to hurt, and never too late to know they were untrue. You were always worth wanting.

YOUR TURN

Has a hurtful sentence found you later in life, not just in childhood? Write about how you'd mother yourself at the age you are now.

When I was 12, I got locked up for a probation violation. On the phone call, my dad told me, "It's a vacation when you're gone." I've never forgotten how that made me feel.

— shared by a son

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were a kid in trouble who needed his dad, not a relief to be rid of. Your absence should have worried him, and you deserved that.

YOUR TURN

When did you need someone most and feel like a relief to them instead?
Write the words you wish had come through that phone.

"Take it back! I don't want it!" When I was born.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never an "it," and you were never returnable. From your first breath, you were a person worth keeping.

YOUR TURN

Was there a story about your birth that made you feel unwanted? Write a new welcome to the world for the baby you were.

My mother abandoned me at 12. She wanted me to go live with my father, but he didn't want me either. After I hung up the phone, she said, "I guess you'll have to stay now." I'm 47, and I think about it every day.

— shared by a daughter, 40s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never a leftover no one would take. You deserved two parents fighting to keep you, and the fault is theirs, not yours.

YOUR TURN

Have you ever felt like no one wanted to claim you? Write to your 12-year-old self and tell her where she truly belongs.

My mom told me she wished she had miscarried me instead of the baby she lost before me. Basically, she said no child could have turned out worse than me.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never the wrong child to survive. Her grief and anger got pointed at you, but you have every right to be here.

YOUR TURN

What's the cruelest comparison someone made about your existence? Write three true things about who you actually turned out to be.

When I was 51, my mom told me the worst mistake she ever made in life was having kids. That was six years ago, and I've been no contact ever since. It's very bittersweet.

— shared by a daughter, 50s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were not her mistake. Choosing distance after words like that isn't bitterness; it's you finally treating yourself as someone worth protecting.

YOUR TURN

Were you ever called a mistake, in words or in actions? Write about the bittersweet choice you made, or want to make, to protect yourself.

My mom used to tell me she wished she had aborted me. She's gone now. I hope she's looking down and seeing how well I'm doing with my kids, how they love me, and how I raised them the way I wish I'd been raised.

— shared by a daughter, mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your life was never a favor she did you. You broke the pattern, and the love in your home is proof of who you really are.

YOUR TURN

What words about your existence did you have to survive? Write about the parent you became, or the person you are becoming, instead.

I was a twin, and my mum didn't know she was having two. She told me I was the one who wasn't supposed to be here. Now I'm a kindergarten teacher, and I make sure every child knows they have a place in this world.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never the extra one. You were meant to be here, and the belonging you give those children was yours all along.

YOUR TURN

Did anyone make you feel like you weren't supposed to exist? Write about the ways you now make others feel they belong.

"I never wanted you. I could have been a doctor, but I was stuck raising you." That's what my mother said to me when I was 44.

— shared by a daughter, 40s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You didn't steal her dreams. The choices she made were hers, and you were never the price of her regrets.

YOUR TURN

Have you been blamed for someone else's lost dreams? Write your own dream down here, and one step you'll take toward it.

"You're unlucky for me." Thanks, Mom.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never bad luck. Her hard times weren't caused by you, and you deserved to be seen as a gift, not a curse.

YOUR TURN

Were you ever blamed for things going wrong in someone else's life? Write down three good things you brought into the world just by being here.

My mother was shot in a home robbery when I was very young. Later she told a relative, "Why should she have a life when I don't?" The relative told me. She called me terrible names too. She's gone now.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Her pain was real, but it was never yours to pay for. You were always allowed to have a full, good life.

YOUR TURN

Did someone make you feel guilty for having a life? Write about one thing you're living fully that she said you didn't deserve.

*You were never a mistake.
You were a person who
deserved to be wanted.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

03

The Mirror They Handed Me

*For everyone who learned to see their body
through someone else's cruel eyes.*

TOO BIG TO THEM
WHILE I WAS ALREADY STRUGGLING
NOT PRETTY ENOUGH
THE BODY THAT MADE A BABY

I'm always being criticized, especially for my looks. How do people who claim to love you also love pointing out your flaws, then say they're just trying to help? I know I gained weight. I had a child.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your body was never a family project. It carried a child, and it deserves respect, not running commentary disguised as help.

YOUR TURN

Whose "just trying to help" comments about your body still sting? Write a boundary you'd say to them now.

I'd had a terrible day and was resting before a family dinner. My uncle asked my dad if I was seeing anyone. My dad said, "She's too fat. Who would want her?" I was so hurt I don't remember driving home.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were always worth wanting, at any size. Being lovable was never something your body had to earn.

YOUR TURN

Were you ever told your body made you unwanted? Write about someone who wanted you, or who you hope will, just as you are.

I gained some weight during a really hard time while starting new meds. My grandma posted a photo of us online, and my mom commented asking how far along I was. I wasn't pregnant. I had just gained a little weight.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

*You were in the middle of healing, and you deserved gentleness, not a joke.
Your body was doing its best through a hard season.*

YOUR TURN

When did a comment about your body come during a time you were already struggling? Write to yourself in that season with kindness.

On the day of my sister's prom, my gran turned to me and asked, "Are you jealous of her because she's skinnier than you?" I haven't spoken to her in ten years.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never in competition with your sister's body. You deserved to celebrate her day without being made the punchline of it.

YOUR TURN

Has someone set you against a sister or friend over looks? Write something you admire about yourself that has nothing to do with your body.

I came home from my first year at boarding school having gained some weight. At the pool, my mum rubbed sunscreen on my back and said, in front of the whole town, "You have bigger love handles than I do." I had to look up what that meant. I was 12.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Before that day, you loved your body without thinking about it. That comfort was yours by right, and you can find your way back to it.

YOUR TURN

When did you first learn to feel self-conscious in your body? Write to your younger self about how she felt before those words.

My grandma gave me diet pills for my 12th birthday.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

At 12, you needed to be celebrated, not shrunk. There was never anything about your young body that needed fixing.

YOUR TURN

What gift, comment, or lesson taught you that your body needed fixing?

Write the birthday card you actually deserved that year.

I'm naturally thin. No matter how hard I try, I can't gain weight. At my cousin's wedding, my aunt asked in front of everybody if I was a cancer patient.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your natural body was never a diagnosis or a public topic. You deserved to enjoy that day without being made a spectacle.

YOUR TURN

Has your body been talked about as if something was wrong with it? Write one thing your body does for you that you're grateful for.

During the worst of my eating disorder, my grandmother told me she loved me more when I was bigger. I'll never forget or forgive that.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Love that changes with your size isn't the kind you deserve. You were worth loving at every weight, especially when you were fighting to survive.

YOUR TURN

When were you struggling and got hurt instead of held? Write what you needed someone to say during your hardest days.

I was eating at my baby brother's first birthday party when my uncle made a whole scene about how he "didn't know I actually ate." He's a licensed counselor. I've struggled with disordered eating since middle school.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You're allowed to eat in front of anyone without explaining yourself. He should have known better, and you deserved a safe table.

YOUR TURN

Were you ever made to feel watched or judged while eating? Write a permission slip to your younger self to eat freely and in peace.

I feel I'm not pretty enough to have a partner or achieve many things. I told my mom, and instead of showing me I might be wrong, she just nodded, which made me feel even worse. Since I was little, I've suffered mockery, harassment and racist insults.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Her silence was not the truth about you. You deserve to be seen as beautiful, and your worth was never waiting on anyone's approval of your face.

YOUR TURN

When did someone's silence confirm your worst fear about yourself? Write what you wish they had said instead.

When I was 4 or 5, my grandma looked at me and said, "It's such a shame you're not pretty like your cousin." I've never forgotten it.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Nothing about you was ever a shame. A little girl deserves to be delighted in, not compared, and you were always lovely to look at.

YOUR TURN

What's the earliest comment about your looks you can remember? Write a new sentence to that little girl that she can keep instead.

I was nine months pregnant, about to give birth any day to a 10-pound baby, and swollen from preeclampsia I didn't know I had yet. My mom told me I "needed to run a few laps around the house."

— shared by a daughter, mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your body was doing something extraordinary and dangerous. You deserved care and awe in that moment, not a comment about your size.

YOUR TURN

When was your body doing something hard and got criticized instead of honored? Honor it here, the way it deserved.

After my first child, a family member told me my husband was going to cheat on me because I had let myself go. He didn't cheat.

— shared by a wife and mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You didn't let yourself go. You grew and cared for a person, and your worth to the people who love you never depended on your shape.

YOUR TURN

What was said about your body after a big life change? Write a thank-you to your body for what it carried you through.

Days after I gave birth to our second child, my then-husband told me, "You're different. Your body just doesn't turn me on like it used to." I was freshly postpartum.

— shared by an ex-wife

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your body had just brought your child into the world. You deserved tenderness in those days, and his words were a failure of love, not a verdict on you.

YOUR TURN

When did someone make you feel undesirable at your most vulnerable? Write down who you've become since leaving that voice behind.

*Your body was never the
problem. The words were.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

04

Where Grief Should Have Been Held

*For the ones who were left alone with their loss, or
hurt in the middle of it.*

GET OVER IT

THE EMPTY SEATS

IT SHOULD HAVE BEEN YOU

WHAT THEY DID WITH WHAT WAS LEFT

My aunt told me to get over my mom's death. I was 16. I've never talked to her since.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

There was never a deadline on missing your mom. You were a girl who had just lost her mother, and your grief deserved room, not a clock.

YOUR TURN

Has anyone ever rushed you through a loss? Write a letter to your 16-year-old self giving her all the time she needs.

My grandpa lived in another country, so I grew up talking to him on the phone. I finally met him after high school, and he treated me like a princess. He died before I could visit again. My aunt asked why I was crying if I'd only met him once.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Love isn't measured in visits. Years of phone calls built something real, and you were allowed to grieve every bit of it.

YOUR TURN

Who did you love from a distance that others didn't count? Write down one conversation with them you'll always keep.

My father told me I never even liked my grandma because I didn't visit her grave often. She was the only person I ever truly loved. I just couldn't face that she was gone forever.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Staying away from a grave doesn't mean you loved less. Sometimes it means you loved so much that standing there hurt too deeply.

YOUR TURN

Has someone judged the way you grieve? Describe how you honor the person you lost, in your own way.

Two months after my fiancé lost his battle with cancer, my father asked me, "So, when are you going to get yourself a boyfriend?"

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

He wasn't a placeholder to be replaced. You were mourning the life you'd planned together, and that loss deserved patience, not a question about what's next.

YOUR TURN

When has someone treated your loss like it was easy to move past? Write a few lines about the person you were really missing.

Three days after my husband died, my mother kept handling his pillow after I asked her to stop. He hated anyone touching the bed, especially his pillow, and she knew it. She just said, "It's not like I'm hurting anything."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You weren't being petty. You were protecting the last things that still held him, and asking her to stop was completely fair.

YOUR TURN

What small thing did you need someone to respect while you grieved? Write the boundary you had every right to set.

I called for an update on my mother in the hospital, and my sister got on the phone and said, "She's dead." That's how I found out. When I got there, my family told me she'd walked in and said, "Be prepared, someone is going to be dramatic." She meant me.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Falling apart when your mom dies isn't drama. It's love. You deserved to be told gently and held, not mocked before you even walked in.

YOUR TURN

Have you ever been labeled "dramatic" for feeling something deeply? Write how that moment should have gone.

My grandparents said they didn't feel well enough to make the trip to my little sister's funeral. She was only 22, and my heart broke for my dad. A few months later, they drove even farther for another grandchild's high school graduation.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

It was never about the distance. Your sister's life mattered, and so did your dad's pain, even when the people who should have shown up didn't.

YOUR TURN

Who didn't show up when it mattered most? Now write down the names of the people who did.

The evening after I buried my mother, my aunt and cousin from out of state asked if I'd mind them going to the casino, and left me home alone.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You shouldn't have had to be alone that night. Needing company after burying your mother isn't too much to ask.

YOUR TURN

When were you left alone when you needed someone most? Write what you would have wanted someone to do that night.

It wasn't what they said, it was what they did. I have five sisters, and not one of them comforted me when I lost my son. I begged them. We went from inseparable to me not caring about them at all.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Begging for comfort wasn't weakness. You were a mother who had just lost her child, and their silence says nothing about what you deserved.

YOUR TURN

Whose absence hurt more than any words could? Write about the comfort you needed, and who can give it to you now.

My father left us when I was 5. When he died decades later, a half-sister from his second family told me I wasn't welcome at the funeral. She said he didn't want me there because "I wasn't there for him in life."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

He was the one who left. A little girl can't be blamed for not showing up for the parent who walked away from her.

YOUR TURN

Were you ever blamed for a distance someone else created? Write to your 5-year-old self and tell her whose choice it really was.

When my mom died, my mother-in-law said, "Not to be cold-hearted, but she didn't come to your wedding." Mom and I were rebuilding; she just couldn't afford the flight. I was sick and packing up our new home, and she called me lazy and said my mom's funeral was "bad timing."

— shared by a daughter-in-law

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

There is no convenient time to lose your mother. You and your mom were finding your way back to each other, and that was worth grieving.

YOUR TURN

Did someone dismiss a relationship you were trying to heal? Write about one good moment you shared with that person.

"It should've been you." That's what I was told after my father died, right in front of me.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

No one gets to trade your life for another. You survived something terrible that day, and you were always worth keeping.

YOUR TURN

Have you ever been made to feel like the one who should have been lost?
Write three reasons you're glad you're still here.

When my sister's little boy died, she told me it should have been my son instead, because she had done everything right in life.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Her grief was real, but her words were cruel. No child's life is a reward or a punishment, and yours was never owed to anyone.

YOUR TURN

When has someone's pain been turned into a weapon against you? Write the boundary that protects you and your family.

After my brother took his own life, I was told, "Suicides don't go to heaven."

— shared by a sibling

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your brother was in pain, and his life is not defined by how it ended. You deserved comfort that day, not a judgment on someone you loved.

YOUR TURN

What did someone say about your loved one that you wish you could take back from them? Write what you want the world to know about them instead.

My aunt told me my mom was a failure and a horrible person. I lost my mom when I was 12, just weeks before she would have finished her master's degree. She was my best friend, and she had the softest, kindest soul.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You knew your mother better than anyone. Her kindness was real, and nobody's cruel words can rewrite the woman you loved.

YOUR TURN

Has someone spoken badly about a person you loved and lost? Write the truth about who they really were.

My dad died of an overdose when I was 2. All I've ever wanted was to know him and to know he'd be proud of me. Then my mom told me my dad would be disappointed in me. It broke something in me that's still broken.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

*Nobody can speak for a father you never got to know, least of all to hurt you.
You are allowed to believe he would have been proud of you.*

YOUR TURN

Is there someone whose approval you never got to hear? Write the words you imagine they would say to you today.

My dad died when I was in middle school. Years later, I asked my grandma for his ashes. She said no, and my uncle said, "Why should you get them? You never came to visit." I was just a kid. They never reached out except at Christmas.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

A child can't be responsible for keeping a family close. You were a kid who lost her dad, and the distance was theirs to bridge.

YOUR TURN

Were you blamed for not keeping up a relationship when you were too young to? Tell your younger self whose job it really was.

I planned my father's funeral alone while recovering from spine surgery. When my older half-sister pointed out a mistake in his obituary, I snapped. She hadn't helped with anything. She said, "You and your mother may not like that he had a family before you came along, but those of us who were here first do."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Being born later didn't make you love him less. You carried his goodbye almost alone, and a small mistake under that weight is only human.

YOUR TURN

When did you carry something heavy while others watched? Write down everything you handled, and give yourself credit for each one.

I lost my mum four years before my wedding. In his speech, my dad didn't mention her once, because he didn't want to upset his new girlfriend.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your mum belonged in that day. Wanting her remembered wasn't asking too much; it was honoring the person who made you.

YOUR TURN

Who was missing from a big day in your life? Write the words you wish had been said about them.

*Grief is love with nowhere
to go. You were allowed to
feel every bit of it.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

05

The Ones Who Got Blamed

*For everyone who carried the weight of things that
were never theirs to carry.*

IT'S YOUR FAULT THEY'RE GONE

THE FAMILY'S PROBLEM

My brother told me our mother would still be alive if it weren't for me. Never mind that she had dementia and passed away in a nursing home. I haven't spoken to him since.

— shared by a sibling

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

An illness took your mother, not you. Needing someone to blame doesn't make you the one at fault.

YOUR TURN

Have you ever been handed blame that wasn't yours? Write it down, then write whose it really was, or that it was no one's.

When I was 12, I got upset with my mom on a family holiday where the adults were drinking. Afterward, my aunt told me what a horrible person I was. She said my mom had cried to her that she wished her cancer would kill her so she wouldn't make me suffer.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

*A 12-year-old being upset is not a reason for anyone to wish they were gone.
Those were adult feelings, and they were never yours to carry.*

YOUR TURN

What did an adult put on your shoulders as a child? Write a note giving that weight back.

Whenever she was overstimulated, my mom told me I was going to give her a stroke. I've had terrible death anxiety since I was little. Now, if my husband doesn't pick up during the day, I assume something tragic has happened.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never powerful enough to hurt her just by being a child. That fear was planted in you, and you're allowed to set it down.

YOUR TURN

What fear did you carry from something you were told as a kid? Write a calming message to the little you who first felt it.

My biological father abused my older sister before I was even born. When I was born, my uncle blamed me, a literal infant, for what a grown man did.

— shared by a younger sibling

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

A baby can't carry anyone's crimes. What your father did was his alone, and you were innocent from your very first breath.

YOUR TURN

What were you blamed for simply by existing? Write a welcome to the baby you were, the way you deserved to be welcomed.

I'd been bullied for over a year. When I told my mom, she said, "Why can't you just get along with people?" As though it were my fault.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Being bullied was never a sign that something was wrong with you. You needed someone on your side, and you deserved to be believed.

YOUR TURN

When did you ask for help and get blamed instead? Write what you wish she had said and done.

The Christmas before I left for boot camp, my aunt told me I'd ruined the holidays, that they'd never be the same again. She was right. That was over twenty years ago, and I never went back.

— shared by a niece or nephew, 40s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Growing up and leaving isn't ruining anything. You were allowed to build a life, and a holiday isn't worth more than you.

YOUR TURN

Were you ever blamed for spoiling a day just by living your life? Describe the kind of holiday you want to create now.

My stepdad told me I was a cancer to the family and that the only way they would thrive is if I wasn't around. He was angry that I wanted to know my biological dad, after my mom kept me from him my whole life.

— shared by a stepchild

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Wanting to know where you come from is natural, not destructive. You were never the thing holding your family back.

YOUR TURN

Were you ever made to feel like the problem in your family? Write about a place or person where you feel you belong.

"The phone goes both ways." Those words made me blame myself for our lack of connection. But it was never the child's job to make the relationship feel safe and loving.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

It was never your job to chase a parent's love. Keeping the connection safe was theirs to do first.

YOUR TURN

Whose job were you told it was to keep a relationship going? Write a boundary about what you will and won't chase now.

A few months after a suicide attempt, I was still figuring out life and lashed out when I asked for support. My twin told me I was digging a hole and trying to drag everyone down with me, even though I do everything I can to support him.

— shared by a twin

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Asking for help while you're fighting to stay isn't dragging anyone down. You deserve support, and reaching out took courage.

YOUR TURN

When did reaching out for help get turned against you? Name one safe person you can reach for now, and write why.

During one of the hardest times of my life, my aunt wrote me a three-page letter about what an awful niece I was. Now, at family gatherings, she acts like nothing ever happened between us.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You don't have to pretend it didn't happen just because she does. Her letter was about her choices, not your worth.

YOUR TURN

Is there someone who hurt you and now acts like nothing happened? Write the short reply you never got to send.

My family told me they don't like me because I remind them of my biological father. He was a really bad man who did unspeakable things to children.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You share some of his features, not his choices. You are your own person, and you never deserved to pay for what he did.

YOUR TURN

Were you ever judged for who you resemble? Write a list of the things that make you uniquely you.

My father left me when I was a baby and didn't come back until I was older. At 25, I finally blew up at him. Now he thinks I owe him an apology.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your anger made sense. He's the one who left, and you don't owe an apology for finally saying how much that hurt.

YOUR TURN

Is someone waiting for an apology you don't owe? Write the apology you actually deserved from them.

*Some weights were never
yours to carry. You can set
them down here.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

06

The Ones Who Didn't Believe Me

*For the ones who finally found the courage to tell,
and weren't protected.*

YOU'RE LYING

THEY CHOSE HIM

I was 6 the first time I told my mom that my stepdad abused me. She told me I was lying, so I was scared to tell her the last time he touched me. I was 16, and I only told because he abused my little sister.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never lying. You told the truth at 6, and the silence that followed was hers to carry, not yours.

YOUR TURN

When did you tell the truth and not get believed? Write to your younger self:
"I believe you," and keep going from there.

My sister told me the abuse didn't happen, because our uncle never did it to her.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

What happened to you doesn't need a witness to be real. Her story being different never made yours untrue.

YOUR TURN

Has someone used their own experience to erase yours? Write your truth here in one sentence, exactly as it happened.

"I thought it only happened a handful of times." Oh, so that's fine then?

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Once was already too many. There is no number of times that makes hurting a child acceptable.

YOUR TURN

Has anyone tried to shrink what happened to you? Write down what it actually cost you, in your own words, without making it smaller.

My grandmother's boyfriend abused me. When he died, she looked me in the eyes and said, "I'm going to his funeral, because he didn't do anything to me." Years later, when I lost my mom, the whole family said, "It's not my problem."

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

What he did to you was real whether or not he did it to her. You deserved a family that chose you, and you still deserve people who will.

YOUR TURN

Who looked away when you needed them most? Write the name of one person, past or future, who would have shown up for you.

My uncle attacked me, and my grandma told my sister to lie about what happened after I left. I walked home crying and found my mom laughing at me. It still haunts me.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your tears deserved comfort, not laughter. The lie they told protected him; the truth still belongs to you.

YOUR TURN

Was there a moment you came home hurting and weren't held? Describe the welcome you deserved that day, in as much detail as you like.

I was "asking for it" when I was assaulted.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

No one asks to be assaulted. The blame was placed on you so no one had to face the person who actually did it.

YOUR TURN

What blame have you been carrying that was never yours? Write it down, then write whose it really is.

It's not something she said. When I told my mom my partner was abusing me, she called his family and repeated everything. They told him, and he hurt me worse each time. I'm no contact with her now.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Telling her was brave, and what happened next was her betrayal, not your mistake. Protecting yourself now is not cruelty.

YOUR TURN

Who did you trust with something that was used against you? Write a boundary you keep today to protect yourself.

A week after I told my mom her husband had been abusing me, I asked if she would help me. She screamed, "What about my house and my car and my marriage and my life?" I think about it every single day.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never the thing standing in the way of her life. You were her child, and you deserved to be chosen first.

YOUR TURN

Has someone you loved chosen comfort over your safety? Write to your younger self: what should have happened that week?

I was pregnant when I called my mom to tell her he was beating me. She said, "You made your bed, now lie in it." Six months after my son was born, he tried to end both our lives.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You didn't make that bed; he did. Reaching out for help was the strongest thing you could do, and you deserved an open door.

YOUR TURN

When did you ask for help and get a lecture instead? Write what you would say to a friend in that exact situation.

After I was assaulted, my mom asked me, "Do you realize how devastating this is for your dad and me?" I will never fully recover from that sentence.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your pain came first that day. You should never have had to comfort anyone for what was done to you.

YOUR TURN

When did your hurt become about someone else's feelings? Write down what you needed someone to ask you instead.

My uncle said the TV host who catches child predators should be arrested for entrapment. That was the end. He never saw me or my kids again.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your instincts were right. Keeping your children away from someone who defends predators isn't overreacting; it's protection.

YOUR TURN

What did someone reveal about themselves in one sentence? Write the line you drew afterward, and why you're proud of it.

*What happened to you was
real, whether or not they
believed you.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

07

Blood, Paper & Belonging

*For everyone who was made to feel they didn't
truly belong to their own family.*

NOT YOUR REAL FAMILY
CHOSEN, THEN REGRETTED
THE FATHER WHO WASN'T

My uncle, the one who encouraged me to just be myself, died when I was 8. My cousin told me to stop crying, that he wasn't my uncle, because I'm adopted and not real family. The aunts agreed. I'm 34 now, and it still hurts.

— shared by an adopted daughter, 30s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Love made you family long before anyone questioned it. Your grief for him was real because your bond with him was real.

YOUR TURN

Who loved you exactly as you were? Write them a short letter about what they gave you that no one can take away.

She was the grandma I grew up with. At her funeral, when I was 12, I sat in the front with my cousins. A relative tapped my shoulder: "Only her real grandkids sit here." She made me sit in the back. I stopped going around after that.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were family because she loved you, not because of blood. One stranger's rule didn't cancel all those years.

YOUR TURN

Where were you made to feel like you didn't belong? Write the names of the people who have always made room for you.

My wife's grandmother always asks for family photos and says, "I want JUST MY FAMILY in the picture," making sure I know I'm not included. I've been with my wife for over eight years and given her two great-grandchildren.

— shared by a wife

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You are part of this family whether or not she lets you into the frame. The life you've built with your wife is the proof.

YOUR TURN

Have you ever been left out of a family picture, literally or not? Describe a picture of the family you've chosen.

My husband adopted my oldest when she was 2. We hadn't told her yet. His sister told her at 6, out of pure spite. When I asked my husband to talk to her, he said he didn't want to rock the boat. I realized then it was me and her, not us.

— shared by a mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were right to expect your daughter to be protected. Standing up for her was love, not causing trouble.

YOUR TURN

When did someone stay quiet when they should have stood with you? Write what you'll always do for the people you love.

I was adopted before I was a year old. When I was 9, my mother said, "I wish I would've given you back." The whole idea of family fell apart for me that day. I'm 25 now, and I think about it every day.

— shared by an adopted daughter, 20s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

A child can't be returned, and you were never a mistake to be undone. Your behavior at 9 was a child's, not a reason to be unwanted.

YOUR TURN

When did you feel like someone regretted having you? Write a welcome to the child you were, the one she deserved.

My mom said, "I'm here with you instead of my boys," and "I'll just ship you somewhere." I'm the youngest and adopted, so I already didn't feel like I fit in.

— shared by an adopted daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never a package to be sent away. You belonged in that home, and you belong wherever you are wanted now.

YOUR TURN

Where did you feel like the outsider in your own family? Write about a place or person where you finally feel you fit.

It wasn't said to me. After I was born, my dad, who was adopted himself, told my uncle he didn't think he'd ever be able to love me. That wasn't my fault. I was just a baby.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were a baby who deserved love from the first day. His wound was never something you caused or needed to fix.

YOUR TURN

What pain did you inherit that was never yours? Write to your newborn self about the love she was always worth.

My adoptive mom told me my birth mom didn't want me. Turns out she'd been trying to reach me since I was 4, and my adoptive mom hid all the birthday cards. She said, "One day you'll understand when you're a mom." I'm a mom now, and I still don't understand.

— shared by an adopted daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were wanted all along. Being kept from that truth was a loss done to you, not a choice you made.

YOUR TURN

What truth was kept from you growing up? Write the birthday card you should have received, in the words you imagine.

When I was moving out of my childhood home because my parents were divorcing, my dad asked for my house key back and told me I wasn't his daughter anymore.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

A divorce ended their marriage, not your place as his child. His leaving says nothing about how worth keeping you are.

YOUR TURN

Has someone tried to take back your place in their life? Write down who you are, apart from anyone's claim on you.

My dad was never around. I actually first saw him walking past me at a grocery store, and he didn't even notice me. Now, as an adult, I've tried to connect, but he says he can't, because he didn't raise me. He sees me "as the neighbor's kid."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

*You were never a stranger's child; you were his, and he chose not to show up.
Reaching out took courage he never matched.*

YOUR TURN

Who have you kept reaching for who never reached back? Write what you're allowed to stop hoping for, and what you'll hope for instead.

I was 8. My cousin had just been adopted by her stepdad, my stepdad's brother. So I asked my stepdad if he would adopt me. He said no, he didn't want to. I still remember dinner, pork chops, peas and mashed potatoes, trying not to cry while I ate.

— shared by a stepdaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Asking to be his was brave and full of love. His no was about him, not about whether you were worth claiming.

YOUR TURN

When did you ask to be wanted and get turned down? Write back to that 8-year-old and tell her what you see in her.

*Belonging isn't something
anyone gets to take away
from you.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

08

Cradles & Cruel Words

*For the mothers, and almost-mothers, who were
hurt at their most tender moments.*

THE BABIES WE LOST

THE BABIES THEY JUDGED

I had two miscarriages at 20 weeks, and my mom was barely there for me. She kept saying things like "At least you already have kids" and "At least you can try again." Anything starting with "at least" shouldn't be said.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Each baby was their own loss, no matter who else you had. Your grief never needed a silver lining to be allowed.

YOUR TURN

What "at least" have you been handed in your grief? Write the name or the memory you want honored here, without any at least.

I lost my baby, and my mom had to care for me. The first time I bled, I walked out of a bathroom at the store where she works, in blood-soaked pants, while she and her coworkers stared at me. Now, whenever I cry, she says, "Well, I'm also traumatized."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your loss was yours, and it deserved gentleness, not an audience. You don't have to share your grief with the person who left you exposed.

YOUR TURN

When did someone make your pain about their own? Write what you needed the day your world fell apart.

After I miscarried our baby, while I was devastated and still healing, my husband said, "Well, you killed your baby."

— shared by a wife

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You did not kill your baby. You lost them, and your body and heart deserved care, not blame.

YOUR TURN

What cruel line have you replayed since a loss? Write it down, cross it out, and write the truth underneath.

After I lost my baby, a relative told me, "I need to take back the baby outfit I bought, since your baby didn't survive. I'm sure someone else can use it."

— shared by a mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your baby was real and mattered, not a returnable gift. You deserved people who would sit with you in that loss.

YOUR TURN

What small moment made a loss feel even heavier? Write about something you'll keep to remember what you lost.

She stopped speaking to me because I didn't get her a Mother's Day card while I was actively miscarrying.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were in the middle of your own loss. Caring for yourself then wasn't selfish; it was survival.

YOUR TURN

When were you expected to show up for someone while you were breaking?
Write down one thing you can give yourself today instead.

"Go have kids already." This was said to us after at least six rounds of IVF that failed.

— shared by a wife

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your longing and your effort were never the problem. You deserved gentleness, not a demand you'd been fighting to fulfill.

YOUR TURN

What painful question do people keep asking you? Write the reply you wish you could give, honest and unapologetic.

My second son was born early. When I offered my mother-in-law grandparent bracelets so she could visit him in the NICU, she said, "I won't need those. I don't want to get attached in case he dies."

— shared by a mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your son was worth loving from his very first breath. Her fear kept her away; it never made him less worth fighting for.

YOUR TURN

Who wasn't there when you or your child were most fragile? Write who showed up instead, or who you became for your child.

I'm pregnant and struggling, and I told my family I didn't want people at the hospital after I give birth. My grandma said, "They don't care about you, they care about the baby."

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You matter on your own, not just as the way to a baby. Setting boundaries at such a big moment is wise, not selfish.

YOUR TURN

When did you feel like just a means to something someone else wanted?
Write the boundary you're allowed to hold this year.

My son's dad left when he found out I was pregnant, but his parents were thrilled. Four months in, they stopped calling. Years later I learned my mother had told them I'd had an abortion and never to call again. Today my son has a great relationship with them.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You didn't lose them because of anything you did. The truth found its way back, and the family you built is real.

YOUR TURN

What lie cost you something you needed? Write about a relationship that survived despite someone's attempt to break it.

I went through premature menopause at 27, devastated that I couldn't have children. My sister was mad at me and screamed, "You never should have kids anyway." I'll never heal from this. I don't think she knows how much it crushed me.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your longing for children was never proof you didn't deserve them. Your grief is valid, and your heart for love is still yours.

YOUR TURN

What loss did someone turn into a weapon against you? Write how you'd like to grieve it, gently and in your own way.

When I was pregnant with my third son, my grandmother said at Thanksgiving, in front of the whole family, "I hope God takes that baby from you." She apologized nine years later. When she died, I carried her casket. I forgave her. I will never forget it.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your baby was a blessing, never a punishment. Forgiving her doesn't mean you have to pretend those words didn't hurt.

YOUR TURN

Is there someone you've forgiven but not forgotten? Write what forgiveness means to you, and what you still get to keep.

When I was 17, my mom forced me to go to Planned Parenthood and threw away my daughter's first ultrasound. Thank God for the nurse who told me it was my choice, not hers.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your choice was always yours, even at 17. The stranger who reminded you of that was telling the truth.

YOUR TURN

Who was the unexpected kind one in your story? Write them a thank-you note they'll never read, but you deserve to write.

During an argument about abortion, my brother said if I ever got pregnant, he'd tie me down and force me to have the baby. I'm a survivor of sexual assault.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your body belongs to you, and you've already survived someone taking control of it. No one gets to threaten that again.

YOUR TURN

When did someone speak about your body like it was theirs? Write a sentence claiming it as your own.

I'm 31 and the breadwinner of my family. When my mom learned I was pregnant again, she said instead of trying to be more successful, I chose to "spread my legs again." When I told her the baby might not be viable, she said, "You have a choice to abort, why make it hard?"

— shared by a daughter, 30s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You are allowed to build a family and a career at the same time. A worried pregnancy needed her support, not her judgment.

YOUR TURN

When were you shamed for a choice that was yours? Write about what you've already built, and let yourself be proud of it.

I called my mom on speakerphone, with my son in the room, to tell her we were finally pregnant again. She said, "I can't say I'm happy for you!" That was the last time I ever spoke to her. That baby is grown now.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your joy never needed her approval to be real. Walking away protected the happiness you'd waited so long for.

YOUR TURN

What good news did someone refuse to celebrate with you? Celebrate it here, the way it deserved.

When I was pregnant with my second, my boyfriend's first, a family member said to him, "Oh, I thought this baby was just another accident."

— shared by a mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your children are not accidents; they are people you love. How they arrived was never anyone else's to judge.

YOUR TURN

What did someone say about your children that stung? Write what each of them means to you.

When my great-aunt learned I was pregnant, I overheard her telling a relative I'd end up like my mother, never be a good mom, and just party. When I confronted her, she said I was lying. I cut her out completely. My son is better off without her.

— shared by a great-niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Her prediction was never your future. You are the one raising your son, and you're writing a different story.

YOUR TURN

What did someone predict about you as a parent, or as a person? Write about the kind of parent or person you've become.

When I was pregnant, my baby's father said if it was a boy, he'd be in the child's life, and if it was a girl, he wouldn't. I had a girl. He kept his word.

— shared by a mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your daughter was never the reason he left. She was worth staying for, and you stayed.

YOUR TURN

Who left when they should have stayed? Write a note to your child, or your younger self, about who showed up instead.

*You were a mother, a
daughter, a person, in every
one of those moments.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

09

Never Enough

*For everyone who kept trying to be enough for
someone who had already decided they weren't.*

THE DISAPPOINTMENT

TOO HARD TO LOVE

YOUR WINS WERE A THREAT

When I was 17, my father told me, "Every time I see your face, I feel disappointed." I'm 34 now, and I haven't spoken to him since.

— shared by a daughter, 30s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your face was never the problem. His disappointment belonged to him, and you were a whole person worth being glad to see.

YOUR TURN

Who made you feel like a disappointment just for existing? Write what you wish they'd felt when they looked at you.

Shortly after my mom died, when I was 19, my dad told me he was disappointed with how she'd raised me and how I turned out.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your mother's love didn't fail, and neither did you. You deserved comfort in your grief, not a verdict on who you are.

YOUR TURN

Has someone ever criticized the person who loved you most? Write down one good thing that person gave you that still lives in you.

I was 8, helping my dad pour concrete ditches. I was his only help, trying as hard as I could, and he told me I was worthless. Twenty years later I still work construction. He wonders why I don't talk to him.

— shared by a son

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were a little kid doing a grown man's work, and doing your best. That was never worthless — it was loyalty he didn't deserve.

YOUR TURN

When did you give your all and hear it wasn't enough? Tell your younger self what they were actually worth that day.

When I was five, my mother bought me the scarecrow doll from The Wizard of Oz because she said I didn't have a brain. I'm almost 40, and I still struggle with Christmas because of those memories.

— shared by a daughter, 30s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

A gift meant to shame you says nothing about your mind. You were a bright little girl who deserved a present chosen with love.

YOUR TURN

What "joke" about you still stings years later? Write the gift you should have received instead — and why.

My dad kicked me out at 17 and told me I'd be a burden wherever I went.

— shared by a son

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were a kid who needed a home, not a burden to be sent away. Needing care has never made anyone too heavy to love.

YOUR TURN

Were you ever made to feel like too much to carry? Write down three places or people where you've been welcome.

My grandma said that out of all her grandkids, I was the least likely to go to college. Well, I got my master's. And now only a few family members are allowed in my kids' circle, because we're ending the generational trauma.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Their low expectations were never a ceiling. You went further than they imagined, and you're making sure your kids never hear what you heard.

YOUR TURN

What did someone decide you'd never do? Write about the moment you did it anyway.

I wanted to go to cooking school — cooking was the only activity my mom let me do. Instead of encouraging me, she told me they'd hand me a live rabbit and make me kill it, skin it, cook it, and eat it.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your dream deserved curiosity, not a scare story meant to make you quit.

Wanting something for yourself was never foolish.

YOUR TURN

What dream did someone talk you out of? Write it down here, and one small way you could still taste it.

At my cousin's wedding, her new husband looked at me and said, "Oh, I thought you were someone important." I told myself he was joking, but deep down I wasn't sure. I didn't want to cause a scene, so I said nothing.

— shared by a cousin

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You didn't need a title to matter in that room. You were important simply because you showed up with love.

YOUR TURN

Have you ever been made to feel small at a family event? Write the reply you wish you'd given.

My dad told my mom I was the hardest of us three kids to love. All I ever wanted was his time; all he could give was things. I'll never forgive him for saying it — or her for telling me.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Wanting your father's time didn't make you hard to love. It made you a child who needed him, and that was never too much to ask.

YOUR TURN

Who made you believe you were difficult to love? Write a list of the people who have loved you easily.

My mom has never once told me she loves me. She kicked me out at 17. I'm 19 now, and I'm never going to speak to her again.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

The silence was her failure, not proof you were unlovable. The words "I love you" were always yours to deserve.

YOUR TURN

What words did you never hear from your parent? Write them to yourself here, exactly the way you needed them.

My mom told my dad on the phone that it was my birthday. His answer was, "I don't care." I was 4 years old, and I heard the whole thing.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were a four-year-old worth celebrating. His not caring was a hole in him, not a measure of you.

YOUR TURN

Is there a day that should have been happy but hurt instead? Write a birthday wish for the little you who heard that.

My mom told me she "doesn't like me." I was 45 years old. Now she's confused why I'm low contact — and somehow I'm the bad guy.

— shared by a daughter, 40s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Protecting yourself from someone who said that isn't cruelty. You're allowed to step back from people who tell you who they are.

YOUR TURN

Have you been made the "bad guy" for keeping distance? Write the boundary you set, and why you're allowed to keep it.

I was born with an underdeveloped left hand, and my aunt told me that nobody would ever marry me.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your hand never decided your worth or who could love you. Love was never reserved for bodies that look a certain way.

YOUR TURN

What about your body did someone use against you? Write a thank-you note to that part of you instead.

My uncle told me that if I moved away, I'd die bitter and alone. I moved anyway. I've been happily married almost 12 years, with two beautiful kids. I never spoke to that uncle again.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

His warning was fear dressed up as wisdom. You were allowed to leave, and your life proved you could build something good.

YOUR TURN

Who tried to scare you out of a big decision? Write about the life that was waiting on the other side.

I graduated early, at 16. I came home so excited to tell my mom, and she said, "You don't deserve a medal for doing the bare minimum."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Finishing early was never the bare minimum – it was hard work. Your excitement deserved to be met with a smile.

YOUR TURN

What achievement did you rush home to share, only to be brushed off?
Throw yourself the celebration here.

I got into college, and at my high school graduation my dad turned to me and said, "Just because you accomplished something doesn't mean you're better than me." That was the last day I ever spoke to him.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your wins were never a threat to anyone who truly loved you. You were allowed to be proud of yourself that day – and you still are.

YOUR TURN

Whose success made someone in your family feel small? Write down one win you'll never apologize for again.

I got a big role in a one-night school play. My mom came to every one of my brother's shows, but she missed mine. When I got home, she said, "I couldn't sit next to all the proud parents and pretend I was proud of you."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You worked hard and deserved someone in that audience cheering for you. Her pride was missing – your talent wasn't.

YOUR TURN

What moment did you wish someone had shown up for? Write the review you deserved from the front row.

I nearly didn't graduate because I was working doubles to keep our lights on. I still kept my GPA up and walked the stage. On senior photo day, my mom said she "didn't want to go." My grandmother got dressed fast, put on her best wig, and took me herself.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You carried a family on your back and still graduated. You deserved a mother by your side – and your grandmother showed you that you were worth showing up for.

YOUR TURN

Who stepped in when someone else wouldn't? Write them a thank-you letter here.

*You were enough before you
ever had to prove it.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

10

Loved, or Just Useful?

*For the ones who wondered if they were loved, or
just needed.*

RAISED TO TAKE CARE OF THEM
WHAT I SUPPOSEDLY OWED

My parents told me they only raised me so I would take care of them in the future.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were not born to be someone's retirement plan. You were meant to be loved for yourself, with no debt attached.

YOUR TURN

Have you ever felt like your worth was only what you could do for others?
Write three things about you that have nothing to do with being useful.

I worked for my dad on his farm, over 100 hours every week for 12 years, for \$8 an hour. One day he said, "I've done it for 30 years without you, I can do it for another 30 without you." I left that day. I started from scratch at 29, and now I have a great family.

— shared by a son

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your work built something real, and so did you. He may have called you replaceable, but the life you built proves otherwise.

YOUR TURN

When were you made to feel replaceable after giving everything? Write about who you became after you walked away.

I was caring full-time for my mother, father and grandmother, with no help and no thanks. In one week, each of them told me separately, "You'd be fine if it was just me. It's the other two who are too much work."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were holding up three lives while drowning. It's okay to need help, and it's okay to put yourself on the list too.

YOUR TURN

What have you been carrying without anyone noticing? Write down one thing you can hand off, and one thing you can do just for you.

My dad lived in another state, and my mom was on drugs. I was couch surfing to keep CPS from finding out. When I called my dad for food money, he said legally he didn't have to give me anything, because I quit school. I quit because I had nowhere to live. I was 15.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were a child trying to survive, not someone to hold to technicalities. You deserved to be fed, housed and cared for.

YOUR TURN

When did you have to take care of yourself far too young? Write a letter to that younger you, thanking her for getting you here.

My sister said she could no longer help me care for our mom, who had full-blown dementia, because it was affecting her mental health and her relationship. Our mom passed just a few months later.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You showed up when it was hardest, and that love mattered. You deserved a partner in it, not to carry it alone.

YOUR TURN

When were you left to carry a family burden alone? Write what you gave, and let yourself be seen for it here.

When my dad died, my mom cried because she couldn't afford the funeral. My two aunts wrote her a check without hesitation. My grandma, who is rich, said, "I'll match whatever they're giving, but you have to pay me back."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Grief should have been met with generosity, not a bill. The aunts who stepped in showed what real family looks like.

YOUR TURN

Who was the kind one when your family was grieving? Write down one thing they did that you still remember.

My mom offered to watch my daughter so I could work. Then she called and said, "I thought I raised you to be generous," because I didn't give her part of my tax refund. I thank her every day, and treat her when I can. It made me take a step back.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Gratitude isn't measured in money. You can love her and still see that a gift given freely shouldn't come with a bill.

YOUR TURN

When was help you received later used to make you feel guilty? Write a boundary that lets you be grateful without owing.

I'd just had a breakdown. I had lost my job and my finances were taken out of my hands. When I got out of the hospital, my aunt told me, "If I had the space, I'd buy your white leather sofa."

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were a person at your lowest, not a sale. You deserved someone asking how you were, not eyeing what you had.

YOUR TURN

When did someone see what you had instead of how you were? Write the question you needed someone to ask you that day.

I'm homeless in another state. My sister asked to borrow money, so I gave her \$150, more than she asked for. She never paid it back. A few months later, I needed money and asked her. She said, "People have lives too."

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your generosity was real, and so was your need. Your life counts just as much as hers.

YOUR TURN

Who took your kindness but wasn't there when you needed it? Write about someone who gives back to you, or how you'll protect your generosity.

*You were never just useful.
You were always worth
loving.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

11

The Seat at Their Table

*For everyone hurt by the partners, in-laws and
step-families that came with love.*

THEY CHOSE THEIR PARTNER

THE IN-LAWS

ABOUT MY CHILDREN

My mom said to me about my stepdad: "I'll always pick him over you. He's my husband — you're just a reminder of a failed marriage."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never the leftovers of a marriage. You were her child, and you deserved to be chosen first.

YOUR TURN

When were you made to feel second to a parent's partner? Write what it would have looked like to be chosen.

My mom told me she got to choose who I considered family and who I could love, because she made me. It was over my boyfriend of three years coming to Christmas. We don't talk anymore — and that boyfriend is now my husband.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Being born to her didn't give her ownership of your heart. Who you love has always been yours to decide.

YOUR TURN

Has anyone tried to control who you love? Write about the person you chose, and why.

The day after our wedding, my stepdaughter looked her dad in the eye and said she didn't know why he married me — that he could do better. I was sitting right beside him, in a crowded restaurant.

— shared by a stepmother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You joined a family with an open heart, and that deserved respect. Someone else's resentment doesn't make you less worth choosing.

YOUR TURN

When have you felt unwelcome in a family you joined? Write what you brought to it that no one noticed.

My stepdad openly admitted, in front of family and friends, that he treated me badly on purpose because he knew my mom wouldn't do anything. The sad part is he was right. She never did.

— shared by a stepdaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were a child who deserved protection from both of them. His cruelty and her silence were never your fault.

YOUR TURN

Who stayed silent when you needed them to speak up? Write what you wish they had said.

I confided in my ex about my rocky relationship with my mom. Later, he threw it back at me: "No one loves you, not even your own mom." Deep down, that's how I felt — and he said it out loud. It still stings.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

He used your deepest wound as a weapon. Your mother's struggle to love you was never proof that no one could.

YOUR TURN

Has someone used your family pain against you? Write down the names of people who have loved you well.

I was 17, nervous and dealing with things at home, meeting my future mother-in-law in her big house. She asked where I lived, then said it was on "the wrong side of the tracks." I spent 15 years trying to prove her wrong.

— shared by a daughter-in-law

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Where you grew up was never a measure of your worth. You didn't owe anyone fifteen years of proof.

YOUR TURN

Where have you been judged for where you came from? Write about what that place gave you that they'll never understand.

I was seriously sick with heat stroke and asked my in-laws to bring my son some food because I couldn't stand. They said, "Welcome to parenthood!" My husband came home to find me passed out on the floor. I never asked them for anything again.

— shared by a daughter-in-law

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Asking for help when you're sick isn't weakness. You deserved care – and you still took care of your son.

YOUR TURN

When did you ask for help and get mocked instead? Write down who you can call now when you need it.

My in-laws said everyone with their last name has blue eyes. Both of my kids had brown eyes, and I told them brown eyes are dominant over blue.

— shared by a mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your children belong to your family without question. You never had to prove your faithfulness to anyone.

YOUR TURN

Have you ever been accused of something that wasn't true? Write the calm, confident answer you deserved to give.

My husband overheard my family bad-mouthing him at a holiday. He's not a doctor, and I moved states to be with him — but I chose that. He's the kindest man with the biggest heart. He's the best choice I've ever made.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your choice was never theirs to approve. Loving someone kind is its own proof that you chose well.

YOUR TURN

Has your family ever disrespected someone you love? Write down what you see in them that others miss.

My siblings watched my ex abuse me. Afterward, they told me he was still part of the family, and I couldn't expect them to cut him out of their lives.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You deserved siblings who stood between you and harm. Keeping your abuser close was their choice, not a price you had to accept.

YOUR TURN

Who chose comfort over protecting you? Write the boundary you're allowed to keep with them.

I was recovering from a traumatic birth with my second child, and my husband introduced our older son to his new sibling without me. I was so hurt to be left out of that moment.

— shared by a wife

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

That moment was yours too. Your pain after birth deserved gentleness, not being left out of your own family's first memory.

YOUR TURN

What family moment were you left out of? Write it the way it should have happened, with you there.

In a family therapy session, my mother was asked to apologize for putting my son in danger. Her answer was, "Get over it." That was the day I went no contact.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Protecting your child was never overreacting. You chose your son's safety, and that is what a good mother does.

YOUR TURN

When did you choose your children over someone else's comfort? Write about the parent you became that day.

I asked my mom to come watch her grandbaby for two weeks while I started a new job. She didn't come. Six months later, she spent three weeks helping my brother's best friend's wife with her baby.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You asked for help you should have been given freely. Being passed over for a stranger was her loss, not your lack of worth.

YOUR TURN

When did someone show up for others but not for you? Write what showing up for yourself looks like now.

My mother watched every other grandchild but never mine. She holds a grudge against me for something I did, but she forgives everyone else.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your children were never less worthy of a grandmother's love. Her grudge was never theirs to carry.

YOUR TURN

Have your children been treated differently because of you? Write the love letter you want them to always have.

I have six kids, and my parents had a big pond in front of their house. We always worried about the kids near it. My sister-in-law said, "What's the big deal? If you lose one, you have five others." I never looked at her the same.

— shared by a mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Every one of your children is irreplaceable. Your worry was love, not overreacting.

YOUR TURN

When did someone dismiss a fear you had for your kids? Write one specific thing that makes each child you love one of a kind.

My family said my son struggled with reading because I was too lazy to work with him — "He'll be lucky to work in a factory someday." He was later diagnosed with ADHD and dyslexia. With support, he's doing much better.

— shared by a mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You weren't lazy – you were a mother without answers yet. Your son's struggle was never a verdict on his future or on you.

YOUR TURN

What did someone predict about your child? Write down who they're becoming instead.

My daughter told my mother-in-law she wanted a dollhouse for Christmas. In front of the family, she answered that my daughter doesn't even have her own bedroom and our house is too small. We're working so hard. It still makes me cry.

— shared by a mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your home was never too small for love. Your daughter is growing up with parents who try, and that's worth more than any room.

YOUR TURN

Has someone made you feel ashamed of what you could give? Write down what your home gives your family that money can't.

*Love that asks you to
disappear isn't the kind you
owe anything to.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

12

Who I Am Was the Problem

*For everyone who was punished for simply being
who they are.*

My mom told me, "You are a disappointment," because I don't share her political views.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Thinking for yourself was never a failure. You're allowed to believe differently and still be a daughter worth being proud of.

YOUR TURN

When were you called a disappointment for having your own mind? Write down a belief you're proud to hold.

My mom found out I was gay and started yelling and threatening me. As I cried, she turned to my little brother and asked if he could believe it. He said, "Yes, because I'm gay too." He came out just to defend me.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Who you are was never something to be threatened out of you. And someone who loved you stood right beside you.

YOUR TURN

Who stood up for you when you needed it most? Write them the thank-you you've been carrying.

My dad pulled a shotgun on me the night I came out to him and my mom. That moment is burned into my brain. I can't stop thinking about it every time I go home for the holidays.

— shared by a son

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Telling the truth about who you are should never have put you in danger. You were brave, and you deserved safety.

YOUR TURN

Where do old fears follow you when you go home? Write what your younger self needed to feel safe that night.

My dad said we should go back to burning gay people at the stake. I'm gay. He took my coming out better than expected, but I'll never forget him basically saying he wants me, my girlfriend, and my friends dead.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Who you are and who you love was never something to be erased. Your life is worth protecting, and so are the people in it.

YOUR TURN

Did someone say something cruel about people like you without realizing you were listening? Write down what makes your people worth celebrating.

He told me I would get osteoporosis and be fired from my job because I am trans.

— shared by a family member

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Fear-mongering isn't concern. You deserve to live as yourself, and your future isn't his to predict.

YOUR TURN

What scary prediction was used to keep you from being yourself? Write down one good thing that happened because you were true to you.

At a holiday gathering, my aunt got drunk and cursed me out, shoved me around, and got in my face because she thought I was gay. I was 12 or 13. None of the adults said a word. Only the other kids stood up for me.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were a child, and every adult in that room failed you. Nothing about who you are made that okay.

YOUR TURN

When did the grown-ups stay silent? Speak to the kid you were — tell them what you'd have done if you'd been there.

In high school, I asked my dad to take me to a baseball game where I'd meet a boy I liked. My stepmom said no because "Black boys are mean."

— shared by a stepdaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Her prejudice was never a reason to doubt your heart. You were allowed to like who you liked.

YOUR TURN

When did someone's prejudice get in the way of your life? Write about someone they were wrong about.

My sister told me my son's terminal cancer was my fault — that he got sick because I had turned my back on God, since our beliefs don't match.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your son's illness was never a punishment for you. You deserved someone to grieve with, not someone to blame you.

YOUR TURN

Who blamed you for something that was never in your control? Write down what you would say to anyone carrying that same blame.

My granddad said he's afraid of me and my parents because we don't fear God. We believe — we just don't go to church often. He said we should be ashamed to walk down the street, and that we'll burn in hell.

— shared by a granddaughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your faith was never his to measure. You don't have to walk in shame for believing in your own way.

YOUR TURN

When was your faith, or lack of it, judged by family? Write what you actually believe, in your own words.

My aunt told me I'd never become a singer or be famous because I'm dark-skinned.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your skin was never the thing standing between you and your dream. Your voice deserves to be heard exactly as you are.

YOUR TURN

What did someone say you couldn't be because of how you look? Write the dream down anyway, in big letters.

I explained to my dad how new abortion laws would force assault survivors to give birth anyway. His answer was, "Well, that's just the consequence. You should be smart about who you're around."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Being hurt by someone is never the victim's fault. You deserved a father who cared about your safety more than his opinion.

YOUR TURN

When did a family member choose a position over your safety? Write down what caring about you would have sounded like.

*Who you are was never the
problem.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

13

The Words That Cut Deepest

For the words that still echo, years later.

WHEN I WAS SICK
SHOWN THE DOOR
WISHING ME GONE
THE NAMES THEY GAVE ME

My dad told his girlfriend he was visiting me in the hospital because I had leukemia and was dying. He was using it as cover to see another woman. I've never had leukemia. I haven't spoken to him in 15 years.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never a prop in someone else's lie. Walking away from a man who used your life as an alibi wasn't cruelty – it was self-respect.

YOUR TURN

Has someone ever used you to cover for their own choices? Write the boundary you drew, or the one you wish you had.

I went to therapy for over three years. When I finally found the courage to tell my mom, she said, "Your therapist didn't teach you to shut up?"

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Getting help was never a weakness, and finding your voice was never the problem. The work you did for yourself took real courage.

YOUR TURN

What have you done to heal that someone mocked or dismissed? Write down one way that work has changed you.

When I tried to take my own life, my mom started yelling at me, furious, and told me I would never be able to become a doctor.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never a plan that failed – you were a person in pain who needed to be held. Your life matters far more than any career.

YOUR TURN

When you were hurting most, what did you need someone to say? Write it here, and name one person or thing that keeps you here today.

I was 39, going through chemo, and had been no contact with my mother for four years. She left a card on my porch. All it said was that if I would grow up and be an adult, she could be there to take care of me.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Protecting yourself was the grown-up choice, not the childish one. Care that comes with conditions was never the care you needed.

YOUR TURN

Has someone offered love only if you'd give up your boundaries? Write the boundary you're keeping, and why it matters.

I was going through cancer at 43, and when I'd call my dad for support, he picked up and said, "I'm dreading your calls lately because it's depressing." I've never spoken to him since.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your illness was never a burden you put on him. You deserved someone who would pick up gladly – and reaching out was the right thing to do.

YOUR TURN

When did you reach out and get turned away? Name one person who did show up, and write what their support meant to you.

My husband needed life-saving surgery 300 miles from home. I asked my mom to watch her granddaughter for one night so I could be there. She said no — she had a hair appointment. That was the day I went numb to her.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your emergency was never less important than her convenience. Going numb was how you protected your heart when the person who should have come didn't.

YOUR TURN

When did someone choose something small over you in a big moment? Write down who did show up, or who you wish had.

When I was 8 or 9, I didn't want to perform in front of a big group of strangers because of my social anxiety. My dad said, "There is something seriously wrong with you. Go to a doctor."

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Nothing was wrong with you – you were a nervous kid who needed patience.
Being shy was never a flaw that needed fixing.

YOUR TURN

What part of you were you made to feel broken for as a child? Speak to that little one here and tell them what was actually right about them.

I was 13 and had a panic attack during my first job, a nine-hour shift in a busy kitchen. My dad looked at me and said, "You've embarrassed me." My throat closed up instantly.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You weren't an embarrassment – you were a kid in over your head. A panic attack was your body asking for help, not a failure.

YOUR TURN

When did your struggle get treated like a shame? Write what a caring parent would have said to you that day.

A friend of mine took his life in our senior year. One night, after days without sleep, everything fell apart. I told my mom — my only parent — that it made me feel unsure about being alive anymore. She laughed at me. We've never been the same.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your grief and your darkness deserved to be taken seriously, not laughed at. Telling her was brave, and you were right to ask for help.

YOUR TURN

Who or what has helped keep you here through the hardest nights? Write them a thank-you, or write what you'd say to someone you love in that place.

I watched my family treat my mother horribly my whole life. She passed when I was 14. I was kicked out on my 16th birthday, and I never looked back. It stops here. I won't let them do to me what they did to her.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Leaving wasn't abandoning your family – it was refusing to repeat her pain. You were strong enough to end something she never got to escape.

YOUR TURN

What pattern in your family are you choosing to end? Write it here as a promise to yourself and to the ones who come after you.

When I was homeless and asked for help getting into rehab, my dad told my mom to leave me on the side of the road — I was dirty, and I was going to die anyway. They never helped. I pulled through. Now I'm a thriving stay-at-home mom of two. I just needed help, not hate.

— shared by a daughter, mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never disposable. Someone in pain asking for help deserves a hand – and the fact that you rebuilt your life says everything about who you really are.

YOUR TURN

When did you need help and get judgment instead? Write about the person you became anyway.

My brother almost died. I was his medical power of attorney, and I fought for him. Afterward he told me, "If it weren't for you, I'd be dead — and now you're dead to me. You'll never be blessed with my presence again."

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Saving someone's life is never the wrong thing to do. His anger belonged to his own fear, not to your love.

YOUR TURN

Have you ever been punished for caring too much? Write about something you did out of love that you'd do again.

My mother called my entire family – cousins, aunts, uncles, siblings – and told them I wasn't talking to her, so they shouldn't talk to me, because I need to know what it's like to have no one!

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Setting a boundary was never a crime that deserved exile. You are not alone just because she tried to make you feel that way.

YOUR TURN

Has someone tried to turn others against you? Write down the names of people who stayed, or the ones you've found since.

My little brother told me to go kill myself. He knew I was already struggling with those kinds of thoughts.

— shared by a sibling

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Those words were cruel, and they were never true. Your life is worth staying for, and you deserve people who protect you when you're struggling.

YOUR TURN

Who or what gives you a reason to stay, even on the hard days? Write them down here — and if you're in that dark place now, please reach out to someone today.

I was about 20. I was a good kid who stayed home to help take care of my family. My stepdad told me, word for word, that he wouldn't care if I died. He's never properly apologized. I'm 32 now.

— shared by a stepchild, 30s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never someone whose loss wouldn't matter. The care you gave your family proves how much you had to give.

YOUR TURN

What would you say to someone you love if they'd been told their life didn't matter? Write those same words to yourself.

My mother told me she wished I was dead. I was 7.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

No child should ever hear that, and it was never about your worth. You were a little one who deserved to be wanted, and you still do.

YOUR TURN

What do you wish a loving grown-up had told you at 7? Write it here, as if you're finally saying it to that child.

My mom has an anger problem. During one fight, she tried to choke me and said, "I will kill you." My sister pulled her off me and called our dad.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You didn't deserve to be hurt, no matter what the fight was about. Your safety mattered then, and it matters now.

YOUR TURN

Who stepped in for you when it counted? Write down what they did, and what you'd like to thank them for.

My mother called me a whore when I was 13 because I had red lipstick on. I wasn't even sexually active.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Wanting to feel pretty never made you anything shameful. The shame in that moment was hers to carry, not yours.

YOUR TURN

Were you shamed for how you dressed or looked growing up? Wear it here: describe the version of you that gets to feel beautiful without apology.

My stepmom called me "disgusting white trash" because I used food stamps — while I was pregnant with my son.

— shared by a stepchild

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Getting help to feed your family was never disgusting. You were doing what a good mother does: making sure your baby was cared for.

YOUR TURN

When were you shamed for needing help? Write down what that help made possible for you and the people you love.

My mom told me often, always with disgust, "You're nothing like me." And honestly? I'm glad I'm not.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Not being like her was never a defect. The ways you turned out different may be the very things you're proudest of.

YOUR TURN

In what ways are you different from the person who hurt you? Celebrate those differences here, one by one.

I was 5 and nervous on my first day of school, and I had an accident. I was yelled at — "Get out to that bus! Now!" — and I walked into school like that. It went downhill for a long time. But there's light out there. Hang on.

— shared by a child

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Nervous little kids have accidents — it was never something to be ashamed of. You deserved a gentle hand and a clean change of clothes.

YOUR TURN

What early moment made you feel small? Write the hopeful words you'd leave for someone still waiting for their light.

I was crying, and my mom turned to my brother with a smile like, "Isn't she so dramatic?" My brother turned to comfort me instead. I'll never forget her cruelty — or his kindness.

— shared by a sister

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your tears were never a performance. The one who comforted you showed you what love is supposed to look like.

YOUR TURN

Who was the kind one in your story? Write down one thing they did that you still remember.

When I was 12, I moved in with my dad after a hard decision. Visiting my mom, I asked when I'd go home. She said I wasn't leaving. I said, "I'm not happy here." She said, "I don't care if you're happy." I'm 18 now, and I'll never see her the same.

— shared by a teenager

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your happiness always mattered, and speaking up for it at 12 was brave. You knew what you needed long before anyone listened.

YOUR TURN

When did you speak up for your own happiness and get ignored? Write to your younger self that she was right to ask.

My adult son — who I've supported and encouraged his whole life — told me he hoped I'd fall on my face and lose everything.

— shared by a mother

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your love for him was real, and his words don't erase it. You're allowed to be hurt by your own child and still honor what you gave.

YOUR TURN

What hurt has come from someone you raised or cared for? Write what you'd want them to understand someday.

My boyfriend and I have been together since we were 14. When he got me a gift for my 15th birthday, my aunt told her friend on the phone that I must be doing sexual favors for him. I was 14 and a virgin.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were a child, and a sweet birthday gift was just that. Her dirty assumption said everything about her and nothing about you.

YOUR TURN

Were you sexualized or judged before you were even grown? Speak to your 14-year-old self and tell her what was true.

My dad would hit and abuse my siblings and me, then tell us, "Just be grateful I don't molest you like my father did to me."

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Being hurt less than he was hurt was never something to be grateful for. You deserved safety, not a smaller kind of harm.

YOUR TURN

What were you told to be grateful for that was really harm? Write what you truly deserved instead.

*Their words were a
prediction. Not a promise.*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

14

...And Then I Did

*For everyone who was told who they'd never be,
and became it anyway.*

As a kid, they told me I'd never be anyone important. When I said I'd graduate, they laughed — "You won't go anywhere" — and said they'd throw a party when I moved out. I graduated high school two years early. Now I'm finishing college. They don't say anything anymore.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Their laughter was never a forecast. You were always someone important – you just proved it where they could see.

YOUR TURN

Who laughed at your plans? Write the list of everything you've done since.

When I was 16, my father told me I'd be nothing but a trophy wife — that I wasn't smart enough to do anything but look pretty for a man.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your mind was never an accessory. You were always capable of so much more than being looked at.

YOUR TURN

What did someone assume you'd be limited to? Write about who you've become beyond it.

My aunt asked why I was reading business magazines. When I said I might want to start my own business one day, she said no — she didn't read those, and she had a degree. She told me a music magazine was more for someone like me.

— shared by a niece

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Big dreams don't need permission or a degree. You were always allowed to picture yourself as the one in charge.

YOUR TURN

What big dream did someone laugh off? Write down the first step you'd take toward it.

I went back to school to get my degree. My sister-in-law told me I'd never make it. I proved her wrong — I graduated as valedictorian.

— shared by a sister-in-law

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Going back was never too late, and doubting you was never her call. You didn't just finish – you finished first.

YOUR TURN

What did you go back and do when people said you couldn't? Celebrate it here, in as much detail as you want.

My family thought I'd become an addict like my dad, and they were surprised when I graduated high school. I'm not an addict. I graduated high school and college, got married, had three kids, and own my home. My kids don't know those relatives.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your father's struggles were never your destiny. You chose your own path, and you're giving your children a safer story.

YOUR TURN

What family pattern were you expected to repeat? Write about the new one you're building.

The day my dad kicked me out, he told me I'd never be anything — I'd be a bum. It made me work harder, and now I provide not just for myself but for my mom and sister too.

— shared by a son

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

His words were meant to break you, but you built something with them. You became the one your family can lean on.

YOUR TURN

Who told you you'd be nothing? Write down who depends on you now, and how that feels.

I've been addicted to drugs since I was very young, and I got clean this past year. I told my mom I finally applied to college — my plan is to get my doctorate and become a veterinarian. She laughed in my face and made fun of me for five minutes.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Her laughter doesn't get to cancel a year of hard-won recovery. You're allowed to dream big from exactly where you are.

YOUR TURN

What brave step did someone mock? Write a note to your future self about why you took it.

They told me I'd be the first one pregnant and I'd never amount to anything. I own my own home and car, I was the last to have my son, and I graduate with my master's next year.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Their words were a prediction, not a promise. You get to be the one who writes how your story goes.

YOUR TURN

What did someone predict about you that turned out wrong? Write about who you became instead.

I started my own business, and my dad laughed: "How long is this gonna last?" I've tried a lot of careers — EMT, surgical tech, real estate — and never lost my stability. Three years later, my business is still going.

— shared by a daughter

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Trying many paths isn't failure; it's courage. Your business is standing, and so are you.

YOUR TURN

Who doubted something you built? Write down how long it's lasted — and what you're building next.

And then you did.

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE



Letters I'll Never Send

*Say the thing you never got to say. No one will
read these but you — so say it all.*

Dear _____,

Dear _____,

Lined area for writing the letter.

Dear _____,

Dear _____,

Dear _____,

Lined area for writing the letter.

Dear _____,

Where to find support

If you're in danger or thinking about ending your life, please reach out right now. You deserve support.

- **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline** (US) — call or text **988**
- **Crisis Text Line** (US) — text **HOME** to **741741**
- **RAINN Sexual Assault Hotline** (US) — **1-800-656-4673**
- **National Domestic Violence Hotline** (US) — **1-800-799-7233**
- **Postpartum Support International** (US) — **1-800-944-4773**
- **The Trevor Project** (LGBTQ+ young people) — **1-866-488-7386**
- **Outside the US** — find a free, local helpline at **findahelpline.com**

A therapist who understands family estrangement or childhood emotional neglect can also help. You don't have to heal alone.

*You made it to the last page.
What they said was never
the whole story.
You are.*